

Report on the outcomes of a Short-Term Scientific Mission¹

Action number: CA21129

Grantee name: Elena Negrea-Busuioac

Details of the STSM

Title: **Expert-influencers and their role in public opinion negotiations in the digital sphere**

Start and end date: 14/06/2026 to 20/06/2026

Description of the work carried out during the STSM

This STSM had two main objectives: 1) to validate the research design for comparative research on the discursive positioning of expert influencers in digital public opinion negotiations, and 2) to advance the collaboration with Prof. Agnieszka Hess from the Jagiellonian University (JU).

Following Prof. Hess's STSM in Bucharest, I started my visit at JU by revisiting the coding grid for the analysis of the Romanian and Polish expert influencers' discourse on Facebook and YouTube, respectively. The coding scheme was expanded to include both epistemic and deontic markers which were not explicitly described in the previous version of the document. Both Agnieszka and I annotated a small section of our respective datasets. I coded Facebook posts by Cristian Tudor Popescu, a renowned Romanian journalist and commentator, which were retrieved using Apify prior to the STSM.

Our annotation test revealed that the coding grid needed further refinement of the categories, which we achieved after several rounds of discussions. The improved coding grid now consists of the following categories: epistemic language (including the following codes: absolute certainty, probability, doubt, evidentiality), deontic language (absolute obligation, prohibition, moral recommendation, normative evaluation), figurative language (metaphors and analogies, irony (including sarcasm and ridicule), hyperbole, and colloquial language), epistemic-deontic interactions, agenda setting, (context, expert framing) candidate evaluations (framing of 2025 presidential election candidates), action, (policy and platform critique, campaign critique) polarisation (ideological, affective) and negotiation (legitimacy, acceptance).

¹ This report is submitted by the grantee to the Action MC for approval and for claiming payment of the awarded grant. The Grant Awarding Coordinator coordinates the evaluation of this report on behalf of the Action MC and instructs the Grant Holder Manager to verify the grant documents compliance and proceed with the payment.

Since both Romanian and Polish datasets included two very well-known journalists (Tudor Popescu and Rymanovski, respectively), a further reassessment of the material to be annotated was made. We decided to analyse only content by these two journalists, and to exclude scholars for an initial phase of the comparative analysis. Consequently, the literary scholar and the educator/ diplomat who were included in the original application, were excluded to perfectly align the Romanian dataset with the Polish one. Annotating two journalists' discourse online will contribute to the harmonisation of cross-national data and advance the joint investigation into Romanian and Polish expert-influencers.

The crucial aspects of this comparative research were to operationalise the concept of "positioned speakers", and to explore how Romanian and Polish experts use their positioned status to negotiate opinions in the digital media. Therefore, epistemic markers are used to identify how the Romanian and Polish journalists establish their expert status, while deontic markers are used to investigate how these experts establish their moral authority. To negotiate opinions on Facebook or YouTube, these experts must bridge elite intellectual capital with the colloquial, fragmented nature of digital media. Figurative language is used to examine how they negotiate and (possibly) win the opinion space. Finally, the coding grid includes categories for identifying what is being discussed (topics) and how the Romanian and Polish experts negotiate the boundaries of legitimate public opinion.

Description of the STSM main achievements and planned follow-up activities

The STSM achieved its objectives, resulting in an integrated approach to explore the feasibility of cross-national patterns in how "positioned speakers" influence democratic stability across different platforms and linguistic contexts. This STSM directly supported the OPINION mission by advancing the conceptual grounding of opinionated text and defining the expert-influencer role, which aligns with WG1 goals. Furthermore, the mission contributed to testing computational tools, specifically deontic markers, on a non-English language (Romanian). The work involved applying skills acquired through the COpA training school in Salamanca to produce a high-quality comparative dataset.

A validated research design and a methodological instrument were developed and are ready to be used. Agnieszka and I outlined the structure of a co-authored paper targeted at a peer-reviewed international journal, to discuss the results of the comparative analysis, and we agreed on a schedule for completing the annotation and drafting the paper.

In terms of strengthening institutional collaboration with the host university, I held several meetings with researchers affiliated with the Institute of Journalism, Media and Social Communication, where we discussed opportunities for future cooperation. These discussions also advanced plans for the joint initiative of an annual seminar titled "Polish-Romanian Dialogues", which will be organised in partnership with the Polish Institute in Romania, the City of Kraków, and the Polish-Romanian Society in Kraków. The seminar is designed to rotate locations annually between Bucharest and Krakow, with the inaugural edition scheduled for 2027.

Finally, during the STSM, I delivered an invited talk titled "Romania's 2025 presidential elections: When emotions run high". This presentation took place on June 15, 2026, in Toruń, during the seminar "Architecture of affect: research trends in political communication". The event was co-organized by the Political Communication Section of the Polish Communication Association and the Institute of Information and Communication Research at Nicolaus Copernicus University (UMK).